Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Religion

Meaning, Functions, Types...

Definition

MELFORD E. SPIRO

An institution consisting of culturally patterned interaction with culturally postulated superhuman beings

- In other words, religion is that part of a group's cultural heritage that mediates between the profane world of everyday life and the sacred world of supernatural beings and powers
- A system of values and a system of rituals coordinate this interaction

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Definition

E.B. TYLOR

A belief in supernatural beings

ANTHONY F.C. WALLACE

"Religion is the beliefs and practices concerned with supernatural beings, powers and forces"

Definition

Emile Durkheim

A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things (things set apart and forbidden) which unite into one single moral community called the church, all those who adhere to them.

He emphasized **three aspects of religion.**

- **The Sacred Aspect**
- **The Social Aspect**
- **The Moral Basis**

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

The Sacred Phenomena

- Religion according to Durkheim includes the Sacred Phenomena only
- Each society distinguishes between two levels of reality; the Sacred and Profane
- The sacred is the extraordinary world which is supernatural in existence
- The profane is the ordinary every day natural world

The Social Aspect

- Religion according to Durkheim has Social Significance
- Religion exists in a social context - implies that religious beliefs are an expression of the way a society orders its way of life
- Religion explains to the human kind the reasons why the society, the world and the universe exist the way they do
- Religion justifies the social order that people believe in

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

The Moral Aspect

- Religion has a moral basis according to Durkheim
- This is because it imposes a **Moral Pressure** on the people to act in accordance with what is believed to be right and proper
- Religion offers a guide to behavior among people
- Thus, religion is an important mechanism of **Social Control**

Characteristics of Religion

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Characteristics

The Holy

- Religious belief or experience is usually expressed in terms of holy or sacred
- The holy is usually in opposition to everyday life
- It carries with it a sense of supreme value and ultimate reality
- Holy may be God or a diffused power
- It is in reality a projection of human mind or some sort of illusion

Characteristics

Response:

- Response to holy takes form of participation in customs or rituals of a religious community
- Response can also be a commitment to faith
- Faith is not nearly a belief but also involves a commitment to the holy
- Faith tends to shape all of a person's life and character

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Characteristics

Belief:

- As religious traditions develop, they generate a system of beliefs with respect to both practice and doctrine
- Belief makes the world intelligible vis-à-vis the holy
- In primitive religions, beliefs take form of **Mythology** and in modern religions they take form of **Theology**.

Characteristics

Rituals and Liturgy:

- Religious traditions invariably involve ritual and liturgical forms
- They may take the form of sacrifice, sacrament or passage rites, prayer, fasting and also pilgrimage
- Participation in communal rituals marks a person as a member of the religious community

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Characteristics

Ethical Codes:

- Ethical Codes are incumbent upon members of a religious community - Caste and Hinduism
- Some religions believe righteous acts as true expressions of religion rather than cultic acts
- Sometimes religions get totally absorbed in **morality**.

Characteristics

Community:

- Religion has a social aspect that leads its adherents to form a community with organized structure
- Earlier religious communities were part of larger communities
- But, as societies evolved, religious communities have become distinct from civil societies and even came into conflict

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Approaches to Study of Religion

Evolutionary, Psychological and Functional Approach

Evolutionary Approach

- **John Lubbock** (1834–1913). His book, *The Origin of Civilization and the Primitive Condition of Man* - Atheism, fetishism, nature worship, and totemism, shamanism, anthropomorphism, monotheism, and ethical monotheism.
- **E.B. Tylor – Primitive Cultures** - animism is the earliest and most basic religious form. Out of this evolves fetishism, belief in demons, polytheism, and, finally, monotheism.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Evolutionary Approach

- **Herbert Spencer** (1820–1903) in his *Principles of Sociology*, **ancestor worship** is the basic source of religion.
- **Robert Ranulf Marrett** classifies religion into five forms: Animism, Animatism, Nature worship, Polytheism, and Monotheism.
- **Emile Durkheim** says totemism is the most elementary form of religion

Evolutionary Approach

- **Max Muller** says that naturalism is the earliest form of religion.
- **Swanson** suggests a four fold classification of religious forms such as Animism, Ancestral worship, Polytheism and Monotheism.
- **Anthony Wallace** classifies world religions into four forms viz., Shamanic religion, Communal religion, Polytheism and Monotheism – based on degree of specialization of religious personnnel

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Evolutionary Approach

- **Sir James Frazer,** in his **The Golden Bough – A History of Myth and Religion,** believes that religion is the result of the development of the original magic stage of human culture.
- **Auguste Comte,** the father of modern sociology, in his **The Positive Philosophy,** has given three stages in the evolution of human thinking.
  - **Theological or fictitious stage** – Fetishism, Polytheism, Monotheism
  - **Metaphysical or Abstract stage**
  - **Scientific or Positive stage**

Psychological Approach

- **Robert Ranulph Marrett** believes that religion is not a problem-solving phenomenon (as the evolutionists believed) and answering the questions of man is not the basis of religion.
- Religion is a profound emotional response to various aspects and these emotional aspects act as a anchor in giving religion a rationale for its existence.
- These theories – Emotive Theories

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Emotive Theories

- **Fear:** According to **Wilhelm Wundt,** religion is a projection of fear into the environment.
- **Rudolf Otto (The Idea of the Holy)** says that religion is identical to numinous feeling – something pertaining to divinity.
- The sense of mystery and fear attached to religion is usually numinous emotion that is always paired with fear towards the uncanny (supernatural or weird).

Emotive Theories

- **Unspecified Emotion:** According to **William James,** the phenomenon of religion is not associated with any particular or specific type of emotion though he admits that religion has a strong emotional base – a mixture of many different emotions
- **Fetishism:** Fetishism implies undue emotional attachment to some object – it is not dead, but has a spirit
- **Animatism – Robert Ranulf Marrett** – Animatism is the rudimentary form of religion – a raw impersonal power that influences human beings

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Functional Approaches

- Evolutionary approach did not yield any decisive result in the origin and evolution of religion
- Anthropologists started looking at the functional significance of religion
- Functional approach is basically the role religion plays in the life of the individual and the society
- Durkheim's definition has emphasized the social role religion plays

Functional Approach

1. **Religion is an instrument of social integration**
   a. **Disciplinary** Function – imposing self discipline on an individual
   b. **Cohesive** function – through ceremonials rituals etc., brings people together
   c. **Revitalizing** function – making the society aware of common heritage, thus motivating people to carry on
   d. **Euphoric** function – aids in pleasant feelings of social well-being, especially in times of calamities, losses and despair

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Functional Approach

2. Religion is a source of conflict
3. Religion gives meaning to subjective experiences
4. Religion gives explanation to the unknown
5. Religion stimulates aesthetic expression
6. Religion is a source of social welfare
7. Social control, moral values and normative reinforcement

Monotheism & Polytheism

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Monotheism & Polytheism

- Monotheism is a belief in the existence of one god, or in the oneness of God;
- Polytheism is the belief in the existence of many gods,
- Atheism is the belief that there is no god.
- Many western scholars believe monotheism is a later development to polytheism and is a higher form of religion – but this claim is unsubstantiated
- Further, it is not one god that is affirmed in monotheism but his uniqueness and divine might and power

Basic Monotheism

- The God of monotheism is the **one real god** that is believed to exist
- His essence and character are believed to be **unique and fundamentally different** from all other beings e.g., the gods of other religions.
- God in monotheism is conceived of as the **creator of the world and man**; - history is a manifestation of the divine will.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Basic Monotheism

- God has not only created the natural world and the order existing therein, **but also the ethical and social order**
- God is holy—supreme and unique in being and worth, and can be experienced as a **mysterium tremendum** ("a fearful mystery")
- But the same time as a **mysterium fascinans**, ("a fascinating mystery"), as a mystery with attitudes of both repulsion and attraction, of both fear and love.

Basic Monotheism

- The God of monotheism **is personal** as exemplified by the great monotheistic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam.
- Negatively, monotheistic **conviction results in the rejection of all other belief systems** as false religions
- This rejection partly explains the exceptionally aggressive or **intolerant stance** of the monotheistic religions in the history of the world.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Types and Subtypes

- What we discussed is a basic type of monotheism
- However, a wide range of positions exist between monotheism and polytheism
  - Exclusive Monotheism
  - Pluriform Monotheism
  - Religious Dualism
  - Polytheism
  - Henotheism
  - Unlimited Polytheism

Exclusive Monotheism

- For exclusive monotheism only one god exists; other gods either simply do not exist at all, or, at most, they are false gods or demons;
- Other gods, if exist, cannot be compared in power with the one and only true God.
- Judaism, Christianity, and Islam.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Exclusive Monotheism

- Two types of exclusive monotheism – **Ethical and Intellectual**
- **Ethical Monotheism** – Man chooses one God because he only needs him and no body else and this God enforces all the ethical order in the world
- **Intellectual Monotheism** – Logical result of all questions pertaining to origin of the world and this God rules through dogmas and doctrines
- African Religions – One God is intellectually superior to all the other Gods that operate in the world

Pluriform Monotheism

- Here the various gods of the pantheon, without losing their independence, are considered to be manifestations of one and the same divine substance.
- It is one of the efforts to solve the problem of the coexistence of divine unity and divine pluriformity (multiplicity of forms).
- Nilotic Religions like among Nuer – "Kwoth" / Oglala Sioux of US – "Wakan Tanka"

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Religious Dualism

- In this belief system, the universe is seen as comprising two usually opposed principles, such as good and evil or spirit and matter.
- Here there are no two Gods – but one God and an anti-God
- Ex. Zoroastrianism – Ormazd (the good God) and Ahriman (the evil God) and are implacable enemies

Polytheism

- Polytheism is the belief in many gods.
- Typically, polytheistic cultures include belief in many demonic and ghostly forces in addition to the gods
- Some polytheistic religions have one supreme creator and focus of devotion, sometimes some gods are considered less important and sometimes some gods are more dominant than the other gods

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Henotheism

- Henotheism (from Greek heis theos, "one god")— is a belief in worship of one god, though the existence of other gods is granted
- Also called kathenotheism (Greek kath hena theon, "one god at a time")
- It is possible to address this god as if he were the one and only god, without, however, belittling the real existence of the other gods (Polytheism is not abandoned)
- Ex. Early Egyptian religion

Unlimited Polytheism

- This form constitutes **extreme polytheism** and is seen in the classical religions of Greece and Rome:
- Each god has his own name and his own shape, and cannot be exchanged with those of any other god
- The number of divinities is large and in principle unlimited.
- There are differences of status and power among the gods, of function and sphere of influence, but they are all equally divine.
- Indian Pantheon – Millions of Gods

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Sacred Vs Profane

Introduction

- **Emile Durkheim** understood religion to involve two absolutely opposed categories, the sacred and the profane.
- Human beings have different attitudes towards these two entities
- Profane is the realm of routine experience and deals with mundane activities
- The profane world is transcended by religion

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

The Sacred

- The attitude elicited by the symbols that represent the sacred is one of intense respect. It is one of awe.
- This may be seen in the fact that sacred things are always set apart by interdictions (formal taboos and authoritative prohibitions) and isolated by ritual practice.
- Durkhiem defines sacred as **the things set apart from the profane and forbidden**

The Sacred

- The reason why sacred is forbidden lies in the fact that profane entities will defile the sacred if they are allowed to intermingle.
- In order to approach the sacred entities, one must attain a degree of sacredness.
- Durkheim regards the sacred-profane dichotomy as of **universal validity.**
- In all the religions, certain objects, precepts, maxims and symbols are regarded as sacred.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

The Source of Sacredness

- The source of sacredness does not lie in the intrinsic properties of the object, nor is sacredness a result of some kind of revelation.
- It is the result of **"Collective Consciousness"** - society attributes sacredness to certain objects.
- Therefore, the source of holiness of the holy water is not because of the chemical composition of water or because God revealed this fact, but it lies in the fact that holiness is attributed to water by the collective thinking of the people.

Characteristics of Sacred

1. **Sacred is an aspect of human experience** – it involves recognition of, or a belief in power or force.
2. **Sacred is characterized by ambiguity** - in that they are physical and moral, human and cosmic, positive and negative, favorable and unfavorable, attractive and repugnant, helpful and dangerous to man.
3. **Sacred is non-utilitarian**. Utility and everydayness are foreign to the sacred. Utility is part of profane.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Characteristics of Sacred

4. **Sacred is non-empirical** in the sense that it is not an aspect of the object but is super-imposed upon it.
5. **Sacred does not involve knowledge**. The sacred is not a matter of knowledge based on the experience of the senses.
6. **Sacred is supportive and has strength-giving character**. Sacred forces act on believers and worshipers to strengthen and sustain them.
7. **Sacred makes a demand on the believer** and worshiper. It impinges on human consciousness with moral obligations.

Origin of Sacred

- Durkheim says the origin of sacred can be found in Totemic beliefs
- Ex. Arunta – An Australian Aborigine with strong totemic religion
- In Totemism, tribes are divided into clans whose solidarity derives not from kinship, but from a religious relationship between its members.
- This relationship is based on a sacred association between the clan, its members and a totemic entity, usually a local animal or plant species.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Totemic Beliefs

- Essential to Australian totemic belief, was the idea that the totemic emblem, a design representing the clan's totemic entity, was sacred.
- The emblem confers sacredness on whatever was marked with it.
- The totemic emblem is used to mark certain objects used in rituals: stones, pieces of wood etc.
- Among the Arunta these objects were known as churingas.



Totemic Beliefs

- Not only were the totemic emblem and the ritual objects sacred: so too were the totemic entity and the human clan members.
- Where the totemic entity was an animal or a plant, its sacredness was a matter of it being prohibited as ordinary food to clan members
- The sacredness of clan members themselves was manifest most importantly in the use of their blood in rituals in order to confer power.



Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Criticism

- British Anthropologist Jack Goody criticized the universality of this dichotomy and said in many societies there are no words that translate into sacred and profane
- He says this dichotomy is an extension of European religious thought of natural or supernatural or good or evil etc.
- Religions like Buddhism – do not cultivate this dualism at all

Myths & Rituals

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

What is a Myth?

- Myth is a symbolic narrative, usually of unknown origin, that ostensibly relates actual events and that is especially associated with religious belief.
- Myths are specific accounts of gods or superhuman beings involved in extraordinary events or circumstances in a time existing apart from ordinary human experience.
- The term mythology denotes both the study of myth and the body of myths belonging to a particular religious tradition.

Nature of Myth?

- As with all religious symbolism, there is no attempt to justify mythic narratives
- Every myth presents itself as an authoritative, factual account, no matter how much the narrated events are at variance with natural law or ordinary experience.
- The word myth derives from the Greek mythos, which has a range of meanings from "word," through "saying" and "story," to "fiction";
- The unquestioned validity of mythos can be contrasted with logos, the word whose validity or truth can be argued and demonstrated.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Nature of Myth

- Myth has existed in every society - a basic constituent of human culture.
- A people's myths reflect, express, and explore the people's self-image.
- The study of myth is thus of central importance in the study both of individual societies and of human culture as a whole.

Function of Myth

1. **Explanation**

- The most obvious function of myths is the explanation of facts, whether natural or cultural.
- But the narrative form which a myth uses distinguishes it from a straightforward answer to an intellectual question
- The imaginative power of the myth lends credibility to the explanation and crystallizes it into a memorable and enduring form.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Function oMyth

2. Justification or Validation

- Many myths explain ritual customs, cultic behavior and also they validate themselves

3. Description

- Myths deal with the origin of the world, the end of the world, or a paradisiacal state,
- They are capable of describing what people can never "see for themselves" however rational and observant they are.

Function of Myth

4. Healing & Inspiration

- Myths play a significant role in healing the sick
- Creation myths (Navajo) are recited when an individual's life is in jeopardy

5. Aesthetic Expression & Myths

- The poetic aspects of myth in primitive society is considerable
- Mythology has exerted aesthetic expression in modern societies

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Malinowski's Functional Theory of Myth

- Primitive Psychology – 1926 (An Essay)
- **Myth is more than idle speculation about the origins of things.**
- Believing in a myth is more than infantile self assurance; it is a device of education and learning, of cultural or religious maintenance.
- **"It justifies by precedent the existing order and it supplies a retrospective pattern of moral values, of sociological discriminations and burdens and of magical belief... the myth of magic and religion is definitely a warrant of its truth, a pedigree of its filiation, a charter of its claims to validity".**

Conclusion

- Myths are distinct from folklore and legends in the sense that myths deal with sacred and semi-divine beings in a time when the world was different
- Because they are told in a sacred contest and deal with sacred beings, myths are the timeless handmaiden of religion.
- They are the fertile seabed from which grew the sacred books of great religions of later civilizations.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

What is a Ritual?

- Ritual is the performance of ceremonial acts prescribed by tradition
- Just as language, ritual may be viewed as a system of symbolic acts that is based upon arbitrary rules.
- **A patterned act that involves the manipulation of religious symbols is a religious ritual.**
- Religious symbols may be verbal such as the names for gods and spirits, certain phrases or may be non-verbal or material objects such as masks, statues, paintings, costumes, body decoration or natural objects.

Types of Rituals

1. **Rites of Passage** - marking an individual's transition from one phase of life to another
2. **Rites of Intensification** – directed towards the welfare of an individual or group
3. **Shamanistic Rituals** like Vision Quest involving curing, divination, fortune telling
4. **Celestial Rituals** – performed by clergy for individual or group as a whole

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Components of Ritual

- Most rituals are a combination of
  - Prayer
  - Offerings and sacrifices
  - Manipulation of objects
  - Telling or acting of myths
  - Altering the physiological state of individual's mind like trance
  - Music
  - Dance
  - Drama

Another way of looking at Types of Rituals

Imitative Rituals

- They are rituals which are based on myths or repeat an aspect of a myth

Positive & Negative Rituals

- Positive rituals are concerned with consecrating or renewing an object or individual
- Negative rituals (always in relation to positive ritual) focus more on prohibitions, taboos etc.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Another way of looking at Types of Rituals

Sacrificial Ritual

- "Essay on the Function & Nature of Sacrifice" – Henri Hubert & Marcel Mauss
- A distinctive feature of sacrificial ritual is the total or partial destruction of a victim
- Victim not always human or animal – it can be vegetables, cakes, milk etc.
- The total or partial destruction of the victim may take place through burning, dismembering or cutting into pieces, eating, or burying.

Another way of looking at Types of Rituals

Life Crisis or Rites de Passage

- French Anthropologist Arnold van Gennep's study – a classic work
- Rituals mark transitions from one stage of life to other
- They include rituals of birth, puberty (entrance into the full social life of a community), marriage, conception, and death.
- Rites of passage have often been described as rituals that mark a crisis in individual or communal life.

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Relationship Between Myth & Ritual

Ritual from Myth Hypothesis

- E.B. Tylor
- Myth is science and Ritual is like Technology
- Examples: Christmas, Hajj, Diwali etc.
- Ritual presupposes a myth – myth gives rise to ritual
- Myth is like a proto science which explains the world and ritual is secondary and is application of myth

Relationship Between Myth & Ritual

Myth from Ritual Hypothesis

- Primacy of ritual hypothesis
- William Robertson Smith – in ancient religions ritual is central while in modern – doctrine is important
- The myth that supports ritual can change
- **Frazer** – myth emerges out of ritual during evolution of religion
- According to Frazer, **"myth changes while custom remains constant; men continue to do what their fathers did before them, though the reasons on which their fathers acted have been long forgotten. The history of religion is a long attempt to reconcile old custom with new reason, to find a sound theory for an absurd practice."**

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com

Relationship Between Myth & Ritual

Myth & Ritual are Non Coextensive

- **Walter Burkert** believes myths and rituals were originally independent
- When myths and rituals do come together, he argues, they do so to reinforce each other.
- **Bronislaw Malinowski** says many cultural practices besides ritual have related myths and hence they cannot be coextensive

Download all form :- www.UPSCPDF.com